



When Tests wrap up in just two or three days — especially in the subcontinent — does it hurt the format's appeal?

Home advantage can be abused, of course. And when the temptation is to win at almost any cost, teams sometimes go too far. That series in India last year, for example — dominated by turning tracks — you could tell it wouldn't last five days. And you could probably guess the result going in. But if you're trying to reach the World Test Championship final, you want points and wins — that's the reality.

England's tour of Pakistan last October showed both extremes. One Test was on a flat pitch — Harry Brook's triple hundred was brilliant in its own way. Then the next games, the ball spun, and we watched a side that was dominant unravel.

So yes, pitch preparation can shape a series — that's undeniable. Whether that's right or wrong is

open to debate. Some dream of a unified pitch formula: 'no, no, no, no, no, no. It's only seam, flat and spin' — as if there's a dial you can turn remotely. That would be ideal. But let's be realistic — you take what you get and try to win on it.

The WTC has added context to Tests — but what changes would make the format more relevant and engaging?

The World Test Championship is inevitably flawed — whether it's the percentage system or the points lost for slow over-rates. It's a brave attempt to address the issue, but clearly not enough.

The real problem is that it's not an even contest. Not all top sides play each other, and everything depends on where, how, and who you play. No amount of maths can fix that imbalance.

That said, it does add context — especially for the teams in the top

Captain's statement: Shubman Gill has made a blistering start to the five-Test series in England. Captaining India for the first time, the elegant right-hander has already racked up three centuries — including a commanding double. GETTY IMAGES

four pushing for a final spot. But if you're sitting at number nine, frankly, no one gives a flying fox what happens.

India is in a rebuilding phase under a new captain. If you had a word with Shubman Gill, what advice would you give him on bringing the best out of his players?

Building a team depends on so many things. At the start of the series, people focused on the absence of Rohit (Sharma) and Virat (Kohli). But Shubman stepped up and played beautifully in two Tests.

You don't have to be 34 to lead — you can be 24, if you've got talent, a good head, and a solid technique. That kind of player can fill the gap. If you're one or two players short of a great side, you work around it and trust others to develop.

I trust my old colleague Michael Atherton when he says India won nine of the 10 days. That's not bad for a team supposedly in transition. In Birmingham, they bowled better than us. At Lord's, England finally found something in the ball we hadn't really seen before.

Team-building often comes down to individual moments. Look at Stokes at Lord's — this is the Stokes we've missed: bowling 90 miles an hour, driving the attack forward. You want all your key players at peak performance — that's what shifts a match.

I always say, if six of your XI are playing to their potential, you're in a good position. If six are having a shocker, you're likely coming second. If all 11 hit their peak — you're unbeatable. But that rarely happens. As a captain, you can just try and find a way of motivating or inspiring each and every man to be at his best somehow. That's all you can do.